

Grammar: Sentence Structure and Types of Sentences

Definitions and Examples of Basic Sentence Elements

The [Mastering the Mechanics webinar series](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar) (<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar>) also describes required sentence elements and varying sentence types. Please see these archived webinars for more information.

Key: **Yellow, bold** = subject; green underline = verb, *blue, italics* = object, pink, regular font = prepositional phrase

Independent clause: An independent clause can stand alone as a sentence. It contains a subject and a verb and is a complete idea.

- I like spaghetti.
- He reads many books.

Dependent clause: A dependent clause is not a complete sentence. It must be attached to an independent clause to become complete. This is also known as a subordinate clause.

- **Although I like spaghetti,**...
- **Because he reads many books,**...

Subject: A person, animal, place, thing, or concept that does an action. Determine the subject in a sentence by asking the question "Who or what?"

- I like spaghetti.
- He reads many books.

Verb: Expresses what the person, animal, place, thing, or concept does. Determine the verb in a sentence by asking the question "What was the action or what happened?"

- I like spaghetti.
- He reads many books.
- The movie is good. (The *be* verb is also sometimes referred to as a copula or a linking verb. It links the subject, in this case "the movie," to the complement or the predicate of the sentence, in this case, "good.")

Object: A person, animal, place, thing, or concept that receives the action. Determine the object in a sentence by asking the question "The subject did what?" or "To whom?/For whom?"

- I like *spaghetti*.
- He reads *many books*.

Prepositional Phrase: A phrase that begins with a preposition (i.e., in, at for, behind, until, after, of, during) and modifies a word in the sentence. A prepositional phrase answers one of many questions. Here are a few examples: “Where? When? In what way?”

- I like spaghetti for dinner.
- He reads many books in the library.

English Sentence Structure

The following statements are true about sentences in English:

- A new sentence begins with a capital letter.
 - **H**e obtained his degree.
- A sentence ends with punctuation (a period, a question mark, or an exclamation point).
 - He obtained his degree.
- A sentence contains a subject that is only given once.
 - ~~Smith~~ he obtained his degree.
- A sentence contains a verb or a verb phrase.
 - He **obtained** his degree.
- A sentence follows Subject + Verb + Object word order.
 - **He** (subject) **obtained** (verb) **his degree** (object).
- A sentence must have a complete idea that stands alone. This is also called an independent clause.
 - **He obtained his degree.**

Simple Sentences

A [simple sentence \(https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure#s-lg-box-2835546\)](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure#s-lg-box-2835546) contains a subject and a verb, and it may also have an object and modifiers. However, it contains only one independent clause.

Key: **Yellow, bold** = subject; green underline = verb, *blue, italics* = object, pink, regular font = prepositional phrase

Here are a few examples:

- **She** wrote.
- **She** completed *her literature review*.
- **He** organized *his sources* by theme.
- **They** studied *APA rules* for many hours.

Compound Sentences

A [compound sentence](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure#s-lg-box-2835546) (<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure#s-lg-box-2835546>) contains at least two independent clauses. These two independent clauses can be combined with a [comma](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/punctuation/commas) (<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/punctuation/commas>) and a [coordinating conjunction](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/grammar/conjunctions) (<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/grammar/conjunctions>) or with a [semicolon](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/punctuation/semicolons) (<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/punctuation/semicolons>).

Key: independent clause = **yellow, bold**; comma or semicolon = pink, regular font; coordinating conjunction = green, underlined

Here are a few examples:

- She completed her literature review, and she created her reference list.
- He organized his sources by theme; then, he updated his reference list.
- They studied APA rules for many hours, but they realized there was still much to learn.

Using some compound sentences in writing allows for more [sentence variety](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure) (<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure>).

Complex Sentences

A [complex sentence](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure#s-lg-box-2835546) (<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure#s-lg-box-2835546>) contains at least one independent clause and at least one dependent clause. Dependent clauses can refer to the subject (who, which) the sequence/time (since, while), or the causal elements (because, if) of the independent clause.

If a sentence begins with a dependent clause, note the comma after this clause. If, on the other hand, the sentence begins with an independent clause, there is not a comma separating the two clauses.

Key: independent clause = **yellow, bold**; comma = pink, regular font; dependent clause = *blue, italics*

Here are a few examples:

- *Although she completed her literature review*, **she still needed to work on her methods section.**
 - Note the comma in this sentence because it begins with a dependent clause.
- *Because he organized his sources by theme*, **it was easier for his readers to follow.**
 - Note the comma in this sentence because it begins with a dependent clause.
- **They studied APA rules for many hours** *as they were so interesting.*
 - Note that there is no comma in this sentence because it begins with an independent clause.

- Using some complex sentences in writing allows for more [sentence variety](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure).
(<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure>).

Compound-Complex Sentences

Sentence types can also be combined. A compound-complex sentence contains at least two independent clauses and at least one dependent clause.

Key: independent clause = **yellow, bold**; comma or semicolon = pink, regular font; coordinating conjunction = green, underlined; dependent clause = *blue, italics*

- **She completed her literature review, but she still needs to work on her methods section even though she finished her methods course last semester.**
- *Although he organized his sources by theme, **he decided to arrange them chronologically, and he carefully followed the MEAL plan for organization.***
- *With pizza and soda at hand, **they studied APA rules for many hours, and they decided that writing in APA made sense because it was clear, concise, and objective.***
- Using some complex-compound sentences in writing allows for more [sentence variety](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure).
(<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/scholarlyvoice/sentencestructure>).
- Pay close attention to [comma](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/punctuation/commas) (<https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/punctuation/commas>) usage in complex-compound sentences so that the reader is easily able to follow the intended meaning.

Sentence Structure Video Playlist

Note that these videos were created while APA 6 was the style guide edition in use. There may be some examples of writing that have not been updated to APA 7 guidelines.

- [Structuring Sentences: Types of Sentences \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491588) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491588>).
- [Structuring Sentences: Simple Sentences \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491593) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491593>).
- [Structuring Sentences: Compound Sentences \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491601) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491601>).
- [Structuring Sentences: Complex Sentences \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491603) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491603>).
- [Structuring Sentences: Combining Sentences \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491608) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491608>).
- [Common Error: Unclear Subjects \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491611) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3491611>).
- [Mastering the Mechanics: Punctuation as Symbols \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3437520) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3437520>).
- [Mastering the Mechanics: Commas \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3437931) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3437931>).
- [Mastering the Mechanics: Periods \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3438019) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3438019>).
- [Mastering the Mechanics: Semicolons \(video transcript\)](http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3437532) (<http://academicguides.waldenu.edu/c.php?g=465757&p=3437532>).

Related Resources



[Mastering the Mechanics Part 1: Simple Sentences \(webinar\)](#)

[.https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar#s-lg-box-2773851](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar#s-lg-box-2773851)



[Mastering the Mechanics Part 2: Compound & Complex Sentences \(webinar\)](#)

[.https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar#s-lg-box-2773852](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar#s-lg-box-2773852)



[Mastering the Mechanics Part 3: Revising Sentence Structure \(webinar\)](#)

[.https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar#s-lg-box-2773853](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar#s-lg-box-2773853)



[Engaging Your Reader with Sentence Structure \(webinar\)](#)

[.https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar#s-lg-box-2773849](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/webinars/grammar#s-lg-box-2773849)



[Sentence Structure Basics \(module\)](#) [.https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/modules/grammar#s-lg-box-8548800](https://academicguides.waldenu.edu/writingcenter/modules/grammar#s-lg-box-8548800)

Knowledge Check: Sentence Structure and Types of Sentences

Knowledge Check